

Instagram Feed & Carousel Image Guidelines (2025)

A simple, beginner-friendly guide to choosing the right image sizes for Instagram feed posts and carousels — without cropping surprises.

Why This Guide Exists

If you've ever uploaded a carousel and thought:

- "Why did Instagram crop this?"
- "Why does this slide look different?"
- "Why does 9:16 look broken in the feed?"

This guide answers those questions **without technical jargon**.

The goal:

- Design once
 - Upload once
 - No surprises
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The One Rule to Remember

| The first image in a carousel sets the size for all slides.

Everything else in this guide builds on that.

Instagram Feed Sizes (What Actually Works)

Instagram feed posts support only a few shapes. These are the safe ones.

Recommended Feed Formats

Best → Okay → Avoid

- **4:5 (Portrait)** – best overall choice
- **3:4 (Portrait)** – also safe
- **1:1 (Square)** – classic and reliable
- **1.91:1 (Landscape)** – wide, less common
- **9:16** – uploads, but **not feed-native**

| Important: 9:16 is for Stories and Reels, not carousels.

Exact Image Sizes (Use These)

You don't need to memorize these. They're here for reference.

Feed Posts & Carousels

- **4:5** → 1080 × 1350 px (recommended)
- **3:4** → 1080 × 1440 px
- **1:1** → 1080 × 1080 px
- **1.91:1** → 1080 × 566 px

Stories & Reels (Not Feed)

- **9:16** → 1080 × 1920 px
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Why 4:5 Is the Best Choice

If you're unsure, choose **4:5**.

Why:

- Takes up the most space in the feed
- No forced cropping
- Looks consistent across devices
- Used by most high-performing carousels

This is the safest default for carousels.

How Carousels Handle Images

Instagram does **not** resize each slide independently.

What happens:

1. The first slide sets the aspect ratio
2. Every slide after that is forced into that shape
3. Mismatched sizes get cropped

Common Mistake

- Uploading a **9:16** image first
- Instagram squeezes it into feed limits
- Top and bottom get cut off

Result: broken layout

Simple Carousel Rules

Follow these and nothing breaks:

- Use **one size** for all slides
 - Upload your intended **base slide first**
 - Avoid mixing portrait, square, and vertical images
 - Never use 9:16 as the first slide
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Safe Zones (Where to Put Text)

Even with the right size, Instagram UI can cover content.

Best Practices

- Keep text away from edges
- Center faces and key elements
- Avoid placing text at the very top or bottom

Profile Grid Preview

- Profile thumbnails crop differently
 - Always center important visuals
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Carousels With Video + Images

Same rules apply.

- Videos and images **must match sizes exactly**
 - Mismatched ratios = cropping
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When You SHOULD Use 9:16

Use 9:16 only for:

- Stories
- Reels
- Vertical video ads

If it's full-screen, 9:16 is perfect.

If it's in the feed, avoid it.

A Safe Publishing Workflow

1. Choose **4:5** (or another feed-safe size)
 2. Resize all slides to match
 3. Upload the first slide carefully
 4. Preview before publishing
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Quick Checklist

Before you publish:

- 4:5 chosen for carousels

- All slides same size
- No 9:16 in feed posts
- Text kept away from edges

If all are true, you're good.

Final Thought

Instagram isn't broken — it's just strict.

Once you design within its rules, everything becomes predictable.

This guide exists so you don't have to learn the hard way.